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# Fate's Edge

largeEssential Starting Guide

## 2.2 Difficulty Value (DV)

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largeGM Player Reference One Region, One Road

tshape “The road remembers. Every broken wheel  
leaves a mark, every lit lamp bears witness. The  
only question is: what are you willing to owe?” fill  
Dusana of the Raven Road

**Welcome to Fate's Edge.** This guide contains everything  
you need to start playingcore rules, character creation, one  
region (Acasia), GM procedures, and a starter adventure  
hook. No other books required.

## large1 The Philosophy of Consequence

### 1.1 Narrative First

**Every roll tells a story.** In Fate's Edge, mechanics serve  
the story. When you roll dice, you are not asking “did I  
succeed?”you are asking “what happens next?”

**The Golden Rule:** When in doubt, make the choice that  
serves the story. Set DV=3, Position=Controlled, and let  
the dice fall.

### 1.2 Safety at the Table

Fate's Edge explores mature themes. Use these tools to keep  
play safe:

tem **XCard:** Any player may say “X” to stop a scene.  
No questions asked. tem **Lines:** Content that will  
not appear (e.g., “no harm to children”). tem **Veils:**  
Content that fades to black (e.g., “romance is implied,  
not described”).

Establish these in Session Zero.

## large2 The Core Resolution

### 2.1 The 90Second Loop

tshape Every choice carries weight

Every meaningful action follows this cycle:

DVs to “challenge” playersuse Position instead.

### 2.3 Position

Position tells you how risky the action is and changes how

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## 2.4 The Outcome Matrix

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|-------------|------|
|             | What |
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| DVtent      |      |
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| = no        |      |
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| tion.       |      |
| with        |      |
| DVSB        |      |
| SBIn-       |      |
| tent        |      |
| 0 achieved; |      |
| GM          |      |
| spends      |      |
| SB.         |      |
| Partial     |      |
| Progress;   |      |
| cesses      |      |
| < 1         |      |
| DVBoon.     |      |
| SBMiss      |      |
| = No        |      |
| 0 progress; |      |
| gain        |      |
| 2           |      |
| Boons;      |      |
| GM          |      |
| spends      |      |
| SB.         |      |
| tomrule     |      |

**A Partial is not failure.** It moves the story forward: improve Position for next attempt, reduce DV, succeed at reduced scale, or reveal information.

**A Miss is never “nothing happens.”** The GM must introduce a complication.

## 2.5 Critical Success (10s)

A roll of 10 counts as **two successes**. If the overall roll succeeds:

tem **1 ten**: Strong successimprove Position or gain  
minor advantage. tem **2 tens**: Exceptionalchoose two  
benefits. tem **3+ tens**: Legendarydecisive victory; clear  
1 segment from a relevant timer.

## large3 Resources: Boons Story Beats

### 3.1 BoonsPlayer Currency

Boons represent luck, momentum, and narrative leverage.

**Spend them freely.** [Boons at a Glance]

**cap:** 5 Boons. At end of scene, reduce to 2 (excess lost).

**The Math of Fun:** Hoarding Boons for XP conversion starves the table of drama. A rerolled failure or an improved Position creates a memorable moment. Spend Boons!

### 3.2 Story Beats (SB)GM Currency

Every time a player rolls a 1, the GM gains Story Beats. Spend SB to introduce complications: [SB Spend Menu]

| Complication | Effect                                                     |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Minor        | 1 worsens one step                                         |
| Moderate     | 2 If ready Desperate, 1 die; otherwise Position            |
| Major        | 3 <b>Recovery:</b> Short rest removes 2 Fatigue; worsens 1 |
| Re-          | 4 dice (if already ready Desperate from Fatigue)           |
| in-          | 5 Collapse, KO, incapacitated                              |
| force-       | 6 <b>Recovery:</b> full night's rest removes all.          |
| ments,       |                                                            |
| scene        |                                                            |
| shifts,      |                                                            |
| break        |                                                            |
| an           |                                                            |
| as-          |                                                            |
| set          |                                                            |
| momentum.    |                                                            |

## large4 Injury Exhaustion

## 4.1 FatigueThe Weight of the World

Each point of Fatigue worsens your Position. If already Desperate, each Fatigue imposes 1 die instead. [Fatigue

## 4.2 HarmSerious Injury

|               | line     | width | tom | rule | Effect       |
|---------------|----------|-------|-----|------|--------------|
|               |          |       |     |      | <b>Harm</b>  |
|               |          |       |     |      | <b>Level</b> |
|               | line     | width | tom | rule |              |
|               |          |       |     |      | <b>Harm</b>  |
|               | <b>1</b> | on    |     |      |              |
|               |          | re-   |     |      |              |
|               |          | lated |     |      |              |
|               |          | ac-   |     |      |              |
|               |          | tions |     |      |              |
| [Harm Levels] | line     | width | tom | rule |              |
|               | <b>2</b> | dice  |     |      |              |
|               |          | on    |     |      |              |
|               |          | most  |     |      |              |
|               |          | ac-   |     |      |              |
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|               | <b>3</b> | or    |     |      |              |
|               |          | dy-   |     |      |              |
|               |          | ing   |     |      |              |
|               | line     | width | tom | rule |              |

### 4.3 The RollerCoaster Effect

**Taking Harm clears Fatigue.** The shock of a wound resets your exhaustion. This creates dramatic swings a character near collapse who takes a wound and finds a second wind.

#### 4.4 Armor Conversion

When you take Harm, armor converts some to Fatigue: [Ar-

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mor Conversion]
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1 1 2
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## large5 Building Your Character

### 5.1 10Minute Checklist

Start with **32 XP** (max 36 with Bonds/Complications).

tem **Concept:** One sentence (origin, profession, defining trait). tem **Attributes (15):** Spend XP<sub>primary</sub> to 3 (9 XP), secondaries to 2 (6 XP each). tem **Skills (05):** Spend 812 XP on key skills. tem **Talents:** 13 talents (26 XP each). tem **Patron (optional):** Choose a Patron for magic. tem **Assets/Followers (optional):** Minor Asset (4 XP) or follower (Cap<sup>2</sup> XP). tem **Bonds Complications:** Up to +4 XP total.

## 5.2 Attributes

**Example**

| Skills                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | Notes |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------|
| <a href="#">link to Str</a> ,<br><b>Bog</b> ,<br>en-<br>let-<br>duce,<br>Stealth<br><a href="#">link to WP</a> ,<br><b>In</b> ,<br>quick,<br>think-<br>inges-<br>ti-<br>ga-Cost to raise: New rating    3 XP.<br>tion<br><a href="#">link to Sp</a> ,<br><b>With power,</b><br>in-Re-<br>tu-solve,<br>itionSur-<br>vival<br><a href="#">link to Ph</a> ,<br><b>Gl</b> ,<br>leadCom-<br>er-mand,<br>shipDe-<br>cep-<br>tion |       |

Downtime = new rating in days.

### 5.3 Skills

**Cost to raise:** New level 2 XP. Downtime = new level in  
line with the PL Social  
**Combat**  
line with the PL Tactics  
**Melee**  
line with the PL Skill  
line with the PL Endurance  
days. [Core Skills]  
line with the PL Performance  
line with the PL Insight  
line with the PL Knowledge  
line with the PL Arcana  
line with the PL Investigation  
line with the PL Medicine  
line with the PL Rule

5.4 Sample Starting BuildThe Duelist (32 XP)

tem **Attributes:** Body 3 (15 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP) tem  
**Skills:** Melee 2 (6 XP), Athletics 1 (2 XP) tem **Talent:**  
Keen Senses (2 XP) tem **Total:** 31 XP (bank 1)

large6 The Known World: Acasia

“The Broken Province”

6.1 Genre Mood

**Low fantasy / mercenary realism / border feud.** Acasia festers between the fallen Utaran Empire and the ambitions of petty kings. Every bridge demands a price, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads.

6.2 What You Notice First

The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

6.3 The One Rule That Kills Newcomers

**Never sign a contract on a bridge.** The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

6.4 Key Factions

|           |       |        |       |
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| as        |       |        |       |
| true      |       |        |       |
| sovereign |       |        |       |
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| the       |       |        |       |
| tri-      |       |        |       |
| Curse     |       |        |       |
| archs     |       |        |       |
| line      | width | height | color |
| tomrule   |       |        |       |

6.5 The Curse of Acasia

The land remembers what we didand what we failed to do. Every broken milestone is a forgotten promise. **Mechanical effect:** When you cross a bridge or crossroads, roll Spirit + Resolve (DV 3). On a failure, the Curse stirsgain 1 Fatigue or a minor complication (GM’s choice).

6.6 Acasia MiniGenerator (d6)

tem A bridge toll has tripled overnight; the tollkeeper is a deserter from your old company. tem A hedgewitch offers to break your blooddebtfor the memory of your first kill. tem The Lam King travels with a mute jester who writes prophecies on fallen leaves. tem Bandits stole a Blackwood Matriarch’s cursebox. Recover it before it opens. tem A free company captain wants to hire youbut their last three hires died of “accidents.” tem The Margravine’s seal is missing. Whoever finds it can rewrite border law.

large7 Running Fate’s Edge

7.1 The GM Mindset

You are not a referee. You are a **cocreator of drama**. Your tools (SB, timers) are how you play the game.

7.2 Your Defaults

When in doubt:

tem DV: 3 tem Position: Controlled tem Consequence: Fatigue, time pressure, or exposure tem Timers: One short timer tied to the scene

7.3 The ThreeTimer Guideline

Keep 13 active timers per scene: [Timer Sizes]

7.4 GM Survival Tips

sectionWhen Players Go Off the Rails Do not panic. Ask: “What is your goal?” Name the simplest obstacle then set Position and DV.

sectionWhen Players Hoard Boons Remind them: “Boons are not XP tokens they are dramatic fuel.” Introduce time pressure.

sectionWhen a Scene Stalls Ask a leading question, tick a timer, or cut to another player.

sectionWhen You Don’t Know a Rule Make a ruling that keeps the story moving. Default to DV 3, Controlled Position. Look it up later.

large8 The Lantern at Dusk

A Starter Adventure in Acasia

8.1 Setup

The party is hired by Elder Sarai of Duskwood. A blight is spreading from the old barrow, where a cursed lantern was buried. The lantern must be brought to a stone circle to break the curse.

8.2 What the Party Knows

linkwidth1000When The lantern is in the central chamber of the barrow. tem The barrow is guarded by restless spirits (the Duskwights). tem A rival treasure hunter, Quick Lena, has also entered the barrow. tem The curse will kill the village’s crops in three days.

8.3 Timers

|                                                |                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| linkwidth1000Standard scene or tension problem | linkwidth1000Effect Clock Barrow Collapse lapse [6]side. At 6, entrance seals.  |
| linkwidth1000Extended or [Adventure Timers]    | linkwidth1000Backs Agenda [4]scene in-side. At 4, Lena takes the lantern first. |
| linkwidth1000Epic                              | linkwidth1000rule                                                               |

8.4 Scenes

sectionScene 1The Entry (DV 3, Controlled) Obstacle: Cavein blocks the way (Body + Athletics). Partial: Tick Barrow Collapse +1. Miss: Mark Harm 1, tick Collapse +1.

sectionScene 2The Spirit Corridor (DV 3, Controlled) Three Duskwights demand an offering (a memory or a secret). Roll Presence + Sway. Partial: They also steal random equipment. Miss: They attack (Cap 2, Harm 1 each).

sectionScene 3The Lantern Chamber Quick Lena tries to pry the lantern loose. Confront her: Presence + Sway (DV 3). Partial: She agrees to split the reward but demands a later favor (start Debt Timer [4]).

sectionScene 4Escape (Skill Challenge) The party needs **3 successes before 2 failures** to escape. DV 3, Position Desperate. Each failure ticks Barrow Collapse +1.

## 8.5 Resolution

Return the lantern to the stone circle. Break the curse with Spirit + Lore (DV 2). **Partial:** Curse lifts, but the lantern attracts another danger soon.

## 8.6 Advancement

Each PC earns **610 XP** at the end.

## large9 Basic Magic

## 9.1 The Five Paths (Quick Reference)

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 line width 100, High-R class  
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 ers  
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 play a Runkeeper.

## 9.2 RunkeeperThe Reliable Path

**Requirements:** Familiar (Thiasos, 2 XP) + Codex (4 XP) + Patron.

**Invoking a Rite:** 1 action. Mark +1 Obligation. Effect works as written.

**Push It:** Once per scene, mark +1 Obligation to amplify (+1 die or +1 Effect).

**Obligation Capacity:** Spirit + Presence. Exceeding capacity = 1 Fatigue per segment.

### 9.3 SampleThe Traveler's Runkeeper

### Kestra, Traveler's Runkeeper (36XP)

tem Spirit 3 (9 XP), Wits 2 (6 XP) tem Lore 2 (6 XP), Insight 1 (2 XP), Sway 1 (2 XP) tem Talents: Familiar (2 XP), Codex (4 XP) tem Rites: RoadSense (4 XP), Traveler's Boon (5 XP) tem Obligation Capacity: 4 (Spirit 3 + Presence 1)

## 9.4 Free CastingThe TAGS System

For improvisational magic, construct spells using TAGS:

DV = 1 + number of TAGS

Dangerous TAGS (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate)  
add +2 DV.

## sectionExample Spells

tem **Light** [ILLUMINATE] DV 2. Create small, sustained light. tem **HEAL** [HEAL] DV 2. Remove 1 Fatigue from self or touched ally. tem **Shield of Air** [WARD] [DEFEND] DV 3. Gain Position +1 on next defense. tem **Flame Cloak** [BURNING] [AREA] DV 3. Enemies suffer 1 die to approach.

**Backlash:** On a Miss or when GM spends SB, magic backfires Fatigue 1, Harm 1, or a thematic complication.

## large10 Advancement XP

### 10.1 Earning XP (Per Session)

[XP Breakdown]

|                    | XP          |
|--------------------|-------------|
| Achievement        | 12          |
| Attendance         | 24          |
| Major objectives   | 48          |
| Game pace options: | Gritty (46) |
| Diseries           | 12          |
| Flair              | 12          |
| choices            | 13          |
| Story              | 13          |
| engagement         | 12          |
| Personal goals     | 12          |
| tomrule            |             |

XP/session), Standard (610), Epic (1014).





